come home to my heart

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/23992510.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), best friend squad, Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Angella (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by softsapphiq (softlyhoney)

Summary

"Enough games, Catra," Adora said, her voice commanding. "This ends now."

From her periphery, Catra studied her surroundings; her back was to a solid wall of rock, and she and Adora stood feet away from the edge of a cliff.

"What are you talking about?" Catra demanded. "I don't know you!"

Adora shoved Catra against the rocks. "I said," she growled, "stop. playing. games!"

"And I said," Catra snarled back, pushing as hard as she could, "I don't know what you're talking about!"

Notes

don't ask me how this got so long because i don't know

See the end of the work for more notes

“Your majesty, with all due respect, Glimmer—”

“—disobeyed my orders and entered into a situation which endangered not only herself, but the soldiers under her command.”

Adora shifted on her feet and resisted the urge to grab the hilt of her sword, a nervous habit she’d created over the years. She liked to keep a hold on it, as if that would help her pull it out any quicker if she needed it. “Yes, Your Majesty, but the situation was under control. I found it to be no more dangerous than the battle last week. The Horde’s forces were smaller this time.”

Queen Angella straightened in her throne, now looming even higher than she already had above Adora. There was a warning in her eyes, not quite anger, but more than her usual sternness. “And who was your commanding officer in that battle?”

Adora swallowed, sure she’d already lost the argument. “Commander Netossa, Your Majesty.”

“Exactly.” Angella stood and stepped down from the dais. She began a slow pace in front of Adora, her hands clasped behind her back. “You were under the command of a seasoned leader who has years of experience fighting on the front lines. I understand that both yourself and Commander Glimmer were there to lead the charge in today’s battle, but you are both young and inexperienced.”

“Your Majesty—”

“You were both promoted to commanding officers only this week. I sent you together today because I thought you would help each other plan wise strategies, not rashly charge into battle without nearly enough backup.”

Angella sighed and stopped pacing. She pressed her left hand to her face, massaging her temple. It was a sign of exhaustion not many in Angella’s court were privy to, but having grown up being

practically raised by her as her daughter's best friend, Adora had seen the toll this war had taken on the Queen up close. Her soft pink hair was streaked through with gray, just subtle enough to notice if you were face-to-face. There were lines around her eyes and mouth that made her look older than she really was, and Adora suspected they had more to do with raising a family by herself while also leading a war effort than the typical stresses of everyday life.

Spinnerella and Netossa were only a few years younger than the Queen, but the differences in their appearances were distinct. Adora, when she was really young, used to see Spinnerella and Netossa as older sisters and Angella as a mother.

When Angella looked up at Adora again, her eyes lost the hint of frustration; the worry was plain.

"Adora, you know you are more to me than a soldier. You're just as much my daughter as Glimmer."

Adora's throat tightened, and warmth pooled in her eyes. She inhaled sharply, trying to dispel her growing emotions.

"I can't help but worry when you two go off to fight in a war you've inherited from my generation./that's been raging since well before either of you were born."

"I know you both feel you're ready for more responsibility. I know you want to fight on the front lines. But I've already lost my husband to this war; I can't stand losing my children to it, too." There were tears in Angella's eyes now, and the sight broke Adora's fragile composure. Adora had only seen Angella cry at King Micah's memorial service over a decade ago.

"I understand, Your Majesty," she said, eyes downcast so her tears wouldn't fall.

Angella gave a watery chuckle. "Adora, how many times have I told you that you don't have to address me like that when we're alone? There is no need for formality here."

"Yes, Your Maj—uh, I mean, Angella." Adora scratched the back of her neck, feeling some of her composure return.

Angella smiled fondly at her. Any trace of her tears was gone, only a motherly affection in its place.

"You are dismissed, Adora. Please send Glimmer in on your way out."

Adora saluted and turned on her heel, but as soon as her back was to the Queen, she cringed. Glimmer was going to pick a fight with her mom over this, and Adora and Bow would have to play interference.

Glimmer hated being kept away from the action in the war, and Angella refused to give in. Lately, it seemed like every time they were in a room together, all they did was bicker.

Glimmer wasn't waiting outside the throne room to give Angella her briefing on their mission like she was supposed to. Adora groaned. Glimmer had no problem making Adora's life harder if it also gave her mother a minor inconvenience.

Adora could hear Glimmer grumbling to herself through her bedroom door. Adora rapped once. "Glimmer, your mom wants to talk to you."

Adora heard her huff. "Of course she does. I bet she wants to tell me what a terrible job I'm doing as commander." Before Adora could reply, tell Glimmer to cut her mom some slack, there was a flash of bright light and Glimmer was standing in front of her.

Adora sighed. "You could be nicer to your mom. She is in charge of leading a war effort."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "And I'm trying to help! But she won't let me *do* anything."

Adora put a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Glimmer, it's because she wants to keep you safe. She's scared of you getting hurt out

there—or worse."

Anger flashed in Glimmer's eyes. "Is that what she told you?"

Adora didn't answer. Glimmer shrugged off her hand.

"She seems to forget that she's not the only one who lost someone to this war. I lost my father and my king when she lost her husband. Bright Moon needs me to fight for them, now that he can't."

Adora sighed and let Glimmer walk away from her without another argument. "I'll just be here, I guess."

Adora was hopping between the steps leading up to Glimmer's lofted bed when Glimmer teleported back into her room.

"I can't believe her!" she yelled, nearly making Adora fall off of the step she was on. Adora knew she should be used to Glimmer's sudden appearances by now, but Adora had lost count of how many teleportation-related injuries she'd gotten since Glimmer started learning how to use her powers.

Adora made sure to step down onto solid ground before talking to Glimmer. "What happened?" she asked.

Glimmer huffed and threw herself onto the daybed by the window. "She said I 'disobeyed orders' by not retreating. We were never ordered to retreat!"

"Technically, no," Adora agreed. "But she did tell us not to engage if we ran into the Horde."

Glimmer glared at her. "Whose side are you on?"

"The Rebellion's side—same as you."

"That's not what I meant, and you know it."

“Glimmer, you know I’m not going to get in the middle of this. You’re my best friend, but she’s my queen; I do what I’m told.”

“Apparently not today.”

“Yeah, I know. I’ve already gotten my lecture.”

“Bet she didn’t ground you,” Glimmer mumbled.

“No, she didn’t,” Adora agreed. “But I also didn’t argue with her when she told me off, either.”

“Don’t pretend you don’t know you’re her favorite.”

“I am not! Your mom doesn’t play favorites. Besides, we both know it would be Bow if she did.”

Glimmer laughed, some of the tension leaving her. “That’s because he cleans my room every time he comes over.”

“And he always tries to stop us from getting into trouble.”

“That works about as much as my mom grounding me.”

“Just… Try not to argue with everything she tells you to do.”

“I’ll make no such promises.”

“That’s why I didn’t ask you to promise. Just make an attempt.”

Glimmer looked at her for a minute, considering. Adora gave her a grin.

“Ugh, fine,” Glimmer finally relented. “You win. I’ll *try* to play nice.”

“That’s all I ask.”

Ten minutes later, Glimmer was giving Adora the abridged version of her disaster meeting with her mom. She was telling Adora just how she'd ended up grounded when an arrow flew through the open window.

Glimmer startled, but before Adora could jump to her feet and analyze the potential threat, a note unfurled from the shaft. A doodle of Bow's face stared back at them.

Glimmer rolled her eyes; Adora snorted.

They both leaned out of the window. Bow was standing half-hidden in the shadows of the trees, still holding his bow, grinning wide enough to see it from a distance.

"How many times have I told you not to do that?" Adora whisper-yelled. "If you hit the crown princess, we'll both be dead."

"Yeah, you almost hit me!"

"Hey, guys!" Bow called back at full volume.

Adora put her head in her hands.

"Shh!" Glimmer hissed. She looked over her shoulder, checking for any guards who might've overheard. "What are you doing here?"

"What did you say?" he called back. Before either of them could answer, he yelled, "Come down here!"

"I can't!" Glimmer said, louder while still trying to keep her voice down.

Adora glanced back to make sure the door was locked. It was only a matter of time before Angella came in to try to speak to Glimmer again, after she apparently stormed out earlier.

"She's grounded," Adora told Bow.

"What?" Bow yelled back.

Adora threw her head back, stifling a laugh, as amused as she was frustrated.

"I'm grounded!"

Bow just stared up at them both for a beat, before repeating, "WHAT," for a third time. Even louder.

Glimmer clenched her fists on the windowsill. Adora glanced between her and Bow.

Dread filled Adora's stomach. "Glimmer, don't—"

Glimmer ignored her. She grabbed Adora's wrist and teleported to the grass below.

"I'm grounded!" Glimmer snapped.

Bow screamed.

Glimmer teleported all three of them back into her room before Bow stopped screaming.

"Ugh!" Glimmer said, pacing her room.

"Bad day?" Bow asked.

"My mom is the *worst."*

Bow looked to Adora. "Is this about the siege on Elberon?"

"Yeah."

"I was just trying to defend another one of our villages from falling into the Horde's clutches," Glimmer said, teleporting herself onto her bed.

Adora gave her a look.

"What?" Glimmer asked.

“Didn’t we already go through this?”

“It was my one chance to prove to her that I can do this,” Glimmer insisted.

“No it wasn’t,” Bow said. He was walking around the room and picking things up. “It was your first mission as a commander. You’re not gonna get demoted after one mistake. Besides, Adora was in charge, too. What did Angella say to you?” he asked her.

“That we were too reckless and should’ve retreated.”

“Don’t forget that she didn’t ground you,” Glimmer added.

“We both know you won’t let me,” Adora said.

“I swear she treats me like I’m more fragile than everyone else just because I’m a princess.”

“That doesn’t make any sense,” Bow argued. “Everyone here is a princess. I’m the only one who isn’t.”

Adora coughed.

“And Adora,” he corrected.

“Tell that to my mom.” Glimmer flopped back onto her mattress.

“Hey, where does this thing go?” Bow asked, holding up a now-folded blanket he’d pulled off the floor.

“Bottom drawer,” Glimmer said without looking up.

Adora sat on the daybed and watched Bow methodically tidy up. It was comforting, familiar, after her first mission as a commander went so wrong.

“Besides,” Bow said, “your mom had a point.”

Glimmer sat up and glared at him.

He put up his hands in surrender. “Hey, you know your powers don’t always work that well. And they were the only reason you got out of there.”

Glimmer didn’t budge. “Looking for support here!”

“I’m just saying.” He hopped up onto the first platform leading to Glimmer’s bed. “If you really wanna prove yourself, it’s gonna take more than charging recklessly into battle.” When he reached Glimmer’s bed, he waved Adora over. “Luckily, I’ve got just the thing.”

Adora stood, curious, and started up to Bow and Glimmer.

“Check this out,” Bow said, pulling something out of his pocket.

“Hang on, I’m coming!”

Bow huffed but waited for her.

“Okay, now,” Adora said.

“Ahem,” Bow began. “Check this out! I’ve detected a piece of First Ones tech in the Whispering Woods—a pretty powerful one, too, judging by these readings.”

Adora leaned over Bow’s shoulder, trying to see the tracking pad’s small screen while staying balanced on the small stool they were both standing on.

“What do you think it is?” Adora asked.

“Not sure, but if we find it and bring it back, Angella is bound to be impressed.” Glimmer took the tracker out of his hands and studied it.

Adora’s eyes lit up. “This is perfect! Glimmer can show Angella that she’s capable of handling things on her own, and I can prove to her that I don’t need years of experience as a commander to make my own decisions.”

Glimmer handed the tracker back to Bow. “Did you both forget that I’m grounded?” she asked, annoyed.

Before either of them could argue, someone knocked on the door.

They all froze.

“What do we do?” Adora whispered.

“Nothing, just—stay here and be quiet.”

Glimmer teleported to her door and cracked it open.

“What?” she asked.

“Is someone in there with you?” Angella asked.

Adora and Bow looked at each other, panicked.

“No, Mom. No one’s in here.”

“I heard voices. ‘Grounded’ means no visitors. That includes Adora.”

“She’s not here, Mom! I was just talking to myself.”

Glimmer opened the door wider and went into the hallway. She pulled the door shut, leaving Adora and Bow to listen to Glimmer and Angella’s muffled bickering.

They sat in the relative quiet until Glimmer came back, slamming her door.

“Alright, come down here.”

“What’s going on?” Adora asked. “Did you make up?”

“That did not sound like making up,” Bow said.

“No. We’re leaving.”

“Leaving? Where are we going?” Adora asked.

“To find that thing Bow found in the Whispering Woods.”

Catra groaned and pulled her pillow over her head, trying to ignore the sounds of the other cadets. Way too loud for 6am.

“Get up, Catra,” Lonnie said, throwing a blanket at her head. Catra grumbled and pulled the blanket over herself.

“Seriously, Catra!” Lonnie snapped. “Don’t screw the rest of us over again by not showing up to training.”

Catra only acknowledged her with a finger.

Lonnie huffed. “Fine, don’t come. See if you ever make Force Captain.”

Catra rolled over to face the wall and fell back asleep.

In her dream, Catra was a child again.

She was eight years old, small for her age, with chubby, freckled cheeks and wide eyes. Eyes that still held hope.

She laughed as she ran, breathless, through the Fright Zone. A blonde girl chased after her, a good distance behind. Catra didn’t know who the other girl was, but it felt nice to have someone to play with.

“Catra, wait up!” the girl called.

Catra skidded to a stop when she noticed that Shadow Weaver’s door was open.

“Whoa,” she breathed. “I’ve never seen it open before.”

The room glowed a deep red from within. A giant crystalline structure took up most of Catra’s view.

“We’re definitely not allowed in there,” the girl said.

Catra met her eyes. They grinned at each other.

The girl took off, giggling as she ran. Catra grinned and followed her.

Inside, the ceilings were so high that, even with her head craned all the way, Catra couldn’t see through the shadows to the top.

She walked up to the huge red crystal, jaw slack with awe. “Wow…” She reached out with a finger and poked it.

A jolt of electricity immediately ran through her body, shocking her. “Ah!” She ran to the other girl.

“M-maybe we should get outta here,” the girl said.

Before they could move, Catra heard a strange groaning. She and the other girl ran for a hiding spot.

Shadow Weaver stood in the doorway, one hand braced on the frame for support. She crept slowly into the room, hunched over like she was in pain.

Catra shivered, She’d never seen Shadow Weaver look anything less than commanding. She’d never even thought that Shadow Weaver could get sick.

Shadow Weaver placed a hand on the crystal. It sparked around her hand, but less violently than it had when Catra had touched it. Shadow Weaver walked away and leaned over a large cauldron Catra hadn’t noticed before.

Shadow Weaver removed her mask.

The blonde girl gasped.

Shadow Weaver turned in their direction.

She covered half of her face with one clawed hand. What Catra could still see of her face was covered in scars, and her eyes were bloodshot.

"Get. Out!" she yelled.

Catra took off running.

Before she could escape, though, shadows enveloped the door, trapping her inside the room.

Catra froze, unable to move, to even turn her head. She was under Shadow Weaver's control. Again.

"Catra," Shadow Weaver hissed. "You stay."

Catra felt herself straighten. She was forcefully turned to face Shadow Weaver.

Her mask was back in place, and she stood as tall and menacingly as ever, all traces of her pain from earlier gone.

"Insolent child. I've come to expect such disgraceful behavior from you. But I will not allow you to drag *Adora* down as well."

Adora. She knew that name. Where did she know it from?

Catra heard Adora's voice behind her, but she couldn't make out what she was saying.

Shadow Weaver leaned down into Catra's face. If it weren't for her mask, Catra would've felt her breath on her face.

"If you ever do anything to jeopardize her future, I will dispose of you myself," Shadow Weaver spat.

Catra felt her lungs constrict. She couldn't see anything but Shadow Weaver, and the darkness creeping in around her.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut because it was the only freedom she had over her own body. It did nothing to quell the nausea in her stomach.

Then, all at once, Shadow Weaer's grip on her disappeared. Catra lurched forward and fell to her knees, heaving. She curled into a ball, making herself as small as she possibly could.

When her breathing slowed, she opened her eyes.

Shadow Weaver was gone. Catra wasn't even in her room anymore. She was in her own bed—no, it wasn't her bed. It was a different one, tucked into a corner away from the others.

Catra was curled up at the end of the mattress, a blanket thrown over her. She frowned; she usually slept without covers because she had a tendency to throw them off in the middle of the night. She sat up. When the mattress shifted, someone groaned.

Catra bolted up out of the bed, but the figure in the bed only sat up and mumbled, "Catra? 'S wrong?"

It was the blonde girl from before—Adora—but she was older now, probably around thirteen or fourteen. Catra looked down at her own hands; they were larger than before, but still smaller than normal.

"Uh…" Catra mumbled. "Nothing, just a bad dream. It's fine now."

Adora studied her for a few seconds, skeptical. Then she shrugged, rolled over to face the wall, then went back to sleep.

Catra watched her breathing even out. Who was she? When had she come to the Fright Zone? Catra couldn't remember meeting her before, but she'd apparently been here since she was a child.

And she was a favorite of Shadow Weaver's.

Resentment filled Catra's stomach like acid, until she felt like if she didn't get away from this girl, she would be sick. She ran for the door, but as soon as she opened it, tried to step through, the world spun.

She wasn't in the Fright Zone anymore; she was outside, and she was standing in front of Adora again—only, it wasn't really her.

This Adora was abnormally tall, and her hair hung loose down her back, free from the ponytail she'd been wearing before. She was glowing, too, effervescent, as if liquid sunshine ran through her veins.

She pointed a sword at Catra.

Catra sprang away from her, eyes wide.

"Enough games, Catra," Adora said, her voice commanding. "This ends now."

From her periphery, Catra studied her surroundings; her back was to a solid wall of rock, and she and Adora stood feet away from the edge of a cliff.

"What are you talking about?" Catra demanded. "I don't know you!"

Adora shoved Catra against the rocks. "I *said,"* she growled, "stop. playing. games!"

"And *I* said," Catra snarled back, pushing as hard as she could, "I don't know what you're talking about!"

"People's lives are in danger! Call off your army. Don't punish all of Etheria because you hate me."

"Get *off* of me!" Catra shoved Adora, and this time, she moved. Her foot slid in the dirt, sending her to the ground with a thud. She rolled and tried to push herself back to her feet, but she stopped inches from the edge of the cliff.

Catra tried to back away, but Adora grabbed her by the ankle and pulled her down with her. Adora pinned Catra flat on her back. Catra tried to shove Adora off of her again, but the ground began to crumble away. Chunks of rock fell to the chasm below.

"Move!" Catra screamed. Adora rolled off of her and tried to yank Catra back from the edge, but it was too late. The ground caved in under Catra.

"Catra!" Adora reached down, but Catra couldn't reach her hand.

She fell.

Catra woke with a gasp. She scanned the room around her, heart racing. Her clothes were soaked through with sweat.

She was alone in her bed.

She was safe. She was in the dorm, in her own bed, and she was safe.

Her blanket was twisted around her legs. She thrashed until she was free, then kicked it to the floor.

"What was that?" she said to herself, pushing her hair out of her face. She climbed out of bed and walked to the bathroom. She splashed her face with cold water.

She headed back into the bedroom to get ready.

"Stupid Lonnie and her stupid training," she grumbled. Her knee knocked against a bedpost and she cursed, stumbling over to the dresser to throw on some clean-ish clothes.

She stopped by the locker room to grab her training gear. When she got to the gym they were scheduled to train in that day, Catra hung back by the door, listening. The sounds of fists on metal,

lasers, and grunts filtered out. Catra's ears perked up, and a second later, Kyle cried out in pain. She snickered.

She heard Lonnie yell as she presumably took down the bot that had been chasing them. Catra made her move.

She ran into the training room, spotting Lonnie face-down on the ground. The bot was a few feet away, sputtering smoke, sticking halfway out of a hole in the ground. Catra sauntered over and nudged it with her foot. It crashed as it fell into the hole. Lonnie sat up and glared.

"Are you kidding, Catra?"

Catra crossed her arms and smirked. "I know. I'm good, aren't I?"

Lonnie snarled as she pushed herself to her feet. She stalked over to Catra and jabbed a finger into her chest. "You don't get to walk in here after we do all the hard work and claim the credit."

"Y-yeah," Kyle said, trying to sound authoritative and failing miserably. "We're not little kids anymore. We're not gonna let you get away with it."

Catra stalked up to Kyle. "Oh, really?" she drawled. "Because, last time I checked, you're still the weakest one around here." Catra gave him a push, and he stumbled back into Lonnie.

"That's enough, Cadets," Commander Rogers' booming voice said, walking into the room from behind the one-way glass where he'd been watching. "I've seen everything I need."

"Excellent work," he began, "to those of you who decided to show up on time," he finished. Catra rolled her eyes and crossed her arms. "Rogelio, nice assist. Kyle, stay on your feet next time. Lonnie," he said, walking over to her and clapping a hand on her shoulder. "Excellent leadership. Keep it up, and you could become the next Force Captain."

Lonnie saluted him, ignoring the indignant glare Catra gave her.

“Catra,” the Captain said, levelling his stern glare on her. She didn’t flinch; she was used to it by now. “Care to explain why you were twenty minutes late today?”

He wouldn’t fall for anything she tried to spin, but that didn’t stop Catra from feigning innocence anyway. “I must’ve gotten the time mixed up. I thought we were scheduled for this afternoon. Silly me.”

Rogelio grumbled. Catra ignored him.

“You seem to have these mix-ups an awful lot,” Lonnie said.

“Funny how that happens, huh?”

“Enough excuses,” Rogers cut in. “If you can’t take your training seriously, Cadet, you should reconsider what you’re still doing here.”

Catra felt the blood leech from her face, but she gritted her teeth and refused to show any of the twenty different emotions warring for dominance inside her. Anger, humiliation, envy. Instead, she buried them all.

“You’re dismissed,” Rogers told them.

Catra turned on her heel and left.

Catra was shoving her gear back into her locker when a chill pricked the air. Shadow Weaver silently glided into the room, her mood as unreadable as ever beneath her mask.

“Lonnie,” she said, her low voice travelling through the room. Something hit the floor over in the next row of lockers. Kyle yelped in pain. Shadow Weaver didn’t look at him. “Walk with me.”

Catra watched them walk out of the room together, Shadow Weaver standing closer to Lonnie than she'd ever remembered being with her.

Catra scoffed, disgusted, and headed for the showers.

Lonnie came back as Catra was finishing up in the locker room. There was a confidence to her posture that made Catra instantly suspicious.

"What are you so cocky about?"

Lonnie didn't even give her a dirty look, and that's when Catra knew.

"I've just been promoted to Force Captain," she said, turning so her new badge was in full view. "Looks like you owe me some respect now, Cadet."

Catra scoffed. "*You?* Shadow Weaver made *you* a Force Captain?"

Lonnie's posture grew defensive. "Why is that so hard to believe? You didn't really think you had a chance when you never take training seriously, did you?"

Catra hardened. "Whatever. This place is a shithole anyway."

"If you hate it here so much, why don't you leave?"

Catra laughed once, sharp, bitter. "Brilliant as always. Why didn't I think of just leaving the only home I've ever had?"

"Well, I don't get why you hate it so much. If you actually tried for once and weren't so disrespectful to everyone, you'd be promoted to Force Captain, too."

“Spoken like a true henchman,” Catra said dryly. She didn’t have the energy to remind Lonnie of the countless times she’d tried to win Shadow Weaver’s approval over the years, only to be brutally rejected every time. She’d given up a long time ago trying to suck up to Shadow Weaver.

“The Horde’s not the problem,” Lonnie snapped. “You’ve never cared about our mission.”

“Oh, Lonnie, don’t be upset. If I did care about the Horde, you wouldn’t be Shadow Weaver’s little favorite,” Catra lied. “Really, I’m doing you a favor by giving you an edge.”

Lonnie didn’t look impressed. “If you think you’re better than everyone else, then prove it. I don’t know why you refuse to take up any responsibility and make the rest of us pick up your slack. I’m tired of making excuses for you.”

“I never asked you to. You’re the idiot who started doing that.”

“Why won’t you let anyone get close to you?”

Catra shrank back. She remembered the sight of herself at eight years old, holding hands with a blonde girl with missing teeth and a messy ponytail.

She snarled and shoved her dream out of her mind. That version of herself had never existed. She didn’t know why her brain had suddenly decided to make her ache for something she’d never had, but she swore to forget it.

“Catra, are you even listening to me?” Lonnie asked, irritated. “You know what? Forget it. I’m done trying to help you. It’s not worth it anymore.” She shouldered past Catra and kicked an open locker shut on her way to the showers.

Catra flinched.

Despite everything, years of convincing herself she couldn’t care less about the Horde—its mission, any of the people in it—Lonnie’s

words stung.

She knew no one here cared about her. No matter how hard she tried to please Shadow Weaver, played to her strengths instead of wasting her time trying to best the others at things she'd never be as good at, Shadow Weaver always only cared about where Catra fell short. She didn't have the discipline to wait for orders, she always went off on her own and didn't work with the rest of her team.

Catra had told herself for years that she didn't care about the Horde anymore, didn't care who survived Hordak's never-ending war campaign. But if she didn't have the Horde, what did she have?

"Catra."

The lingering heat on Catra's skin from the shower leached away, leaving her with a bone-deep chill. She turned.

Shadow Weaver stood so still Catra never would've known she was there if she didn't emanate sub-zero temperatures.

"Not paying attention as usual, I see," Shadow Weaver observed.

Catra watched her in silence, waiting.

"Come with me," she said, leaving the locker room as soundlessly as she'd entered.

"Your new superior tells me you continue to have problems with respect and responsibility," Shadow Weaver said as soon as she was inside her office.

Catra lingered in the doorway; she'd never been in there before, and she didn't know how her dream had been so accurate.

“Don’t stand there gaping. Come inside. I didn’t call you here to waste my time,” Shadow Weaver snapped. She stood in the middle of the room, looming menacingly as always. The room was dark, lit only by the tech and a few dim lights.

Catra went to her, and the door locked.

“Yes, Shadow Weaver?” Catra’s voice was steady, unaffected, and she was impressed. Shadow Weaver was creepy enough without a lair.

“Catra,” Shadow Weaver drawled. “I have heard from your new Force Captain that you showed up late to training this morning. Again.”

Catra scowled. Of course Lonnie went and squealed to Shadow Weaver. She’d been given some power, and she was already using it to get petty revenge on Catra.

“Shadow Weaver, I—”

She raised a hand. “Silence. I will not hear any of your excuses. You have proven time and time again that you lack both discipline and respect for your superiors.”

Catra seethed, but said nothing.

“If you ever expect to become more than a cadet, you will have to prove you aren’t as useless as you’ve led both myself and Lord Hordak to believe.” Shadow Weaver turned away and stared at the crystal. “Do not let me hear of any insolence from you to your superiors again, Cadet.” She practically hissed the last word. Without giving Catra another glance, Shadow Weaver said, “You are dismissed. Leave.”

Catra wished she could slam the door behind her, instead of the quiet hiss of the automatic door.

When she was back in the hallway and out of Shadow Weaver’s oppressive presence, Catra slumped against a wall.

She hated it here. Everyone had thought she was worthless for years, and she'd finally decided to stop trying to win their approval.

Lonnie's words from earlier echoed in her mind: *If you hate it here so much, just leave.*

Catra had thought about leaving the Fright Zone more times than she could count. The idea used to feel so dangerous that she'd been afraid to even think about it until the others were asleep at night. She'd been terrified of being caught even thinking about it, as if someone could read her mind.

As she got older, Catra still thought about running away, but only as a distant childish fantasy. Maybe in another life, she'd have been able to escape the first time she'd realized how awful her life was. But Catra wasn't stupid enough to try something she knew she couldn't finish.

Yeah, she could sneak out from the rooftop and scale the fence around the compound, but she'd never been outside the fence before. She wouldn't get far enough on foot before someone noticed her absence. Even if she did, she had nowhere to go and no desire to die in the middle of nowhere.

But now… Lonnie was a Force Captain, and Rogelio wasn't far behind. And Catra wouldn't let herself be a cadet longer than Kyle. But Shadow Weaver made it clear that, as long as she was around, Catra would never become a Force Captain.

The sound of someone whistling came from around the corner. Catra narrowed her eyes. She only knew one person who was obnoxious enough to walk around the Fright Zone whistling and singing to herself.

Before she could overthink it, Catra stepped into Scorpia's view and pretended like she'd been heading in the same direction.

Scorpia stopped whistling as soon as she noticed Catra. "Hey, Catra!" she called, waving a claw.

Catra resisted an eyeroll and pasted on an attempt at a smile. “Hey, Scorpia. Where are you headed?”

Scorpia gasped. “Oh. My. Gosh. Are we small-talking? Is that what’s happening right now? You never small-talk!”

“Don’t ruin it, Scorpia,” Catra said through her teeth.

“Okay, okay, gotcha. I’ll be fun but calm.” Scorpia forced herself to relax her posture. “What did you ask again?”

Before Catra could reply, Scorpia answered her own question. “Oh, right! I’m just headed out to make sure my skiff is charged up and ready to go for my mission tomorrow.”

Catra looked up at Scorpia, still chattering about the rest of her day. A surprised laugh escaped before Catra could control herself. Scorpia didn’t even notice. Catra couldn’t believe she’d gotten so lucky.

Only Force Captains and above had access to skiffs, and Catra had pretty much accepted that her chances of ever getting her hands on one were shot.

She couldn’t believe she’d forgotten about Scorpia. Scorpia had been trying to befriend Catra for at least the last six months, undeterred by Catra’s clear lack of interest. She was flippant with Scorpia at the best of times.

But now…

“Well, if you’re going to your skiff, I guess I’ll see you later.”

“Wait!” Scorpia grabbed Catra’s arm before she could get anywhere. She hid a wince, but Scorpia let go as quickly as she’d grabbed her. “Oh, sorry, sorry. Sometimes I get excited and forget about the claws.”

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"I just—well, you could come with me, if you want. I mean, it's not that big of a deal if you see where the skiffs are kept."

Catra forced herself to hesitate, play the part. "Are you sure that's a good idea? Can't you get in trouble?"

Scorpia waved a claw. "Nah." Then she hesitated. "Well, maybe—but we won't be long. It should be fine."

Catra suppressed a smirk. "If you're sure…"

Scorpia beamed. "Absolutely! C'mon, buddy, it'll be fun."

That night, when Catra was sure everyone who wasn't on night duty was asleep, she snuck out to the garage where Scorpia's skiff was stored. It was laughably easy to sneak past the guards, half of whom weren't paying close enough attention to notice Catra slip through the shadows. There was a reason she still beat the other cadets at drills even when she showed up late: her strengths were speed and stealth.

Catra pulled out the key she'd swiped from Scorpia earlier, starting the skiff with ease. Scorpia had told her all about how to start and pilot a skiff earlier, in what Catra guessed was an attempt to impress her. She didn't remember everything, but it was enough to get her out of the Fright Zone.

Once she was far enough from the compound that she couldn't see the watch towers, Catra let herself relax. After some fiddling, she switched the skiff to auto-pilot so she could focus on coming up with a plan.

She didn't know where she could go before someone either noticed that she or the skiff were missing. She wasn't sure what Scorpia would do for her mission in the morning, but Catra was fairly confident that Scorpia wouldn't rat her out. Lonnie or one of the others she bunked with would do that as soon as they figured

out she was gone. But that wouldn't be until six or seven, so Catra had a few hours of not being chased, at least.

Right now, she was on course for the Whispering Woods. Princess territory, but the trees provided cover for her to stay hidden for a while. It would be tricky to maneuver through the trees, but if she didn't have to worry about being seen, Catra would be fine.

Catra didn't notice when she started to drift down to the forest floor. She only noticed when an alarm started blaring, warning her that she was hurtling at 200 miles an hour toward a boulder that glowed blindingly bright in the darkness.

Adora kicked a rock and tried to tune out Glimmer and Bow's bickering.

"Come on, come on…" Bow had been fiddling with his tracker for the last fifteen minutes. H'ed been trying to get a clear signal after the screen had suddenly blacked out and left them stranded.

"*Please* tell me we're not lost," Glimmer said, pacing circles around him.

Adora sat on a tree stump and propped her chin in her hand.

"No," Bow insisted. "This thing's just acting up."

"Oh, really," Adora muttered.

Bow gave her a look.

"It looks like it's being overloaded by the tech's signal. That's a good thing; means we must be getting close. I'm just not sure which direction we need to go." Still staring at the blank screen,

Bow wandered toward a part of the trees Adora couldn't remember if they'd already been through.

She looked at Glimmer, who was glaring after Bow. Adora shrugged and jogged after Bow.

Before Adora got far, Glimmer said, "Uh, guys, I think it's that way."

Adora pivoted on her heel. "Oh, definitely." Bright blue and purple light emanated from the trees in the opposite direction of where Bow was heading.

"Bow, look."

He finally stopped and looked to where Glimmer was pointing. "Oh."

They made their way into the brush together, slowly at first. Then Bow and Glimmer started trying to edge each other out to take the lead.

"Just let me lead the way," Glimmer snapped.

"The light came from the edge of the forest," he argued.

"I'm the one who found it; you tried to lead us away from it!"

"I'm following the tracker!"

"The tracker's wrong. It's *this* way!"

"Uh, guys," Adora said. She put her arm in front of Glimmer, who walked into it.

"Adora, what—"

"We've got company."

Standing in the middle of the clearing was a girl with wild brown hair in a red Horde uniform. She stared at Adora.

“Horde soldier!” Glimmer yelled.

“I see her!” Bow said.

Then, in what Adora guessed was meant to be a battle cry, Glimmer started yelling.

After a few seconds, Bow joined her.

Adora sighed.

The Horde soldier ran for a tangle of thorny vines where the light shone brightest. Adora ran after her. As she got closer, she saw that a sword wrapped up in the vines was the source of the light.

She didn’t know how a First Ones weapon had managed to stay undiscovered in the Whispering Woods, but she knew she couldn’t let it fall into the hands of someone working for the Horde.

“Guys, a little help!” Adora called over her shoulder.

The Horde soldier was closer to the sword than Adora, but before she could pull it out from the vines, Glimmer teleported to it and got a hand on the sword.

The soldier grunted and lunged for Glimmer, but Glimmer teleported away before the soldier touched her.

Adora grabbed her from behind in a headlock. She thrashed wildly in Adora’s grip, but Adora was stronger.

Glimmer reappeared a few feet away from Adora, and the soldier threw her head back into Adora’s, connecting with Adora’s nose. Adora cried out in pain and instinctively let go of the soldier to cradle her own face. As soon as she was free, the soldier leapt at Glimmer, who shouted, “Bow, catch!” and threw the sword across the clearing.

Somehow, Bow managed to catch it without impaling himself. The soldier gave chase as soon as he had it.

Bow screamed and ran in the opposite direction, but the soldier was quick on her feet and caught up to him easily.

Adora ran to help Bow, but Glimmer teleported right onto the soldier's back with a cry. She hit her back with her fists, and the soldier was more focused on shaking Glimmer off than getting the sword.

She threw Glimmer off of her, who landed on her back with a cry of pain.

Then she whipped out a length of rope weighted down on the ends and threw it at Bow. It wrapped around his ankles, tripping him. The sword flew out of his hands and landed out of his reach. Adora abandoned her plan of helping Glimmer up and ran for the sword.

"Stand down," she called to the soldier, who was nearly to the sword. "We don't want to hurt you."

The Soldier laughed. "I'm not afraid of a couple of princesses."

They were both nearly to the sword, but before the soldier could grab it, Glimmer appeared in front of her and threw a beam of light, blinding her.

While she was distracted, Glimmer threw herself on top of the sword. The soldier, still stumbling, threw herself on top of Glimmer and wrestled her for the sword. Bow threw himself on top of the soldier, who grunted from the weight. As the three of them struggled for control, they rolled away from the sword. Adora lunged for it.

But as soon as she touched the handle, a burst of light exploded from the small blue stone set into the handle. Adora was thrown back into the others, and everything around her went black.

Then, just as suddenly, a torrent of light exploded and sent Adora scrambling away in terror. She gasped and looked around; the

forest was gone. Her friends were gone. The Horde soldier was gone.

"What? What's happening?" Adora asked. "Glimmer? Bow? Can you guys hear me?"

Nothing.

Was she dreaming? She didn't remember losing consciousness, but she didn't know how else to explain what was happening.

Adora put her hands on her head, breathing heavily. "Oh no. This is not good. I can't get separated from Glimmer after we snuck out to the Whispering Woods after curfew when she's grounded! Oh, Angella's gonna kill me."

Before she could spiral further into panic, a monotone voice said, "Hello, Adora."

A tall woman in a veil and cape stood in the center of the room.

Adora gaped at her. "Who are you? Where are my friends?" she demanded.

"Welcome back, Adora."

Up close, Adora could tell that this woman was not Etherian. She was a machine.

Her mouth was moving, but Adora couldn't hear her. A ringing in her ears blocked out everything around her, until Adora had to close her eyes just so she could *think.*

When her mind finally fell quiet enough for Adora to open her eyes, the woman was gone, and the light in the room with her.

Adora was thrown backwards, and in the darkness, all she could see were flashes of a face she knew but didn't recognize.

Warm brown skin, freckles dotted on cheeks, two different colored eyes. A mess of untamed brown hair that stuck out in all directions.

Adora saw herself, wearing not her typical guard uniform but a bright red jacket that bore a Horde badge.

She and the other girl were laughing together, shoving each other playfully as they raced down the hall.

Adora looked around, confused, and saw another image. The same girl, curled up at the end of a bed. Adora was there, too, and they both slept peacefully.

Catra.

The name echoed in Adora's mind. She didn't know how she knew, but as soon as it came into her head, she knew it was the girl's name.

She saw herself, eight feet tall, hair hanging down her back, eyes glowing. She was holding the same sword she'd just found in the forest. Holding it to Catra's neck.

She watched, frozen, as this other version of herself swung the sword.

Adora closed her eyes before she could see it.

Adora groaned and slowly blinked open her eyes. "Ah."

"Adora!" Glimmer yelled in her ear.

"You're awake!" Bow cried.

Adora flinched and rubbed her head. "Ugh, please don't shout."

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asked, reaching for Adora with the hand that wasn’t wrapped around the sword.

“I don’t… What happened?” She sat up slowly and looked around.

Adora started when she saw her. The girl from her vision—dream?—stared back at her. The Horde soldier. Catra.

She sat across from Adora, hands bound with rope. She was glaring at them.

Adora swallowed, unsure of what to say.

“Glad to see you’re not dead, Ponytail,” she said.

“Ponytail?” Adora asked, touching her hair. “What’s wrong with it?”

The Horde soldier snorted. “You princesses are vain, I see.”

“Princess? You think I’m a princess? I’m not a princess.”

Glimmer stood, still clutching the sword protectively to her chest. “Hey, Horde spy,” she said, crouching in front of her. “Care to explain how you made it this far into the Whispering Woods?”

Catra raised an eyebrow, looking about as haughty as someone could look tied up in front of their captor. “I’m not a spy. And what do you mean, how did I make it here? I walked. Is it supposed to be difficult?”

Glimmer’s face tightened in anger. “You’re not a spy? Really?” she asked, planting the blade of the sword into the ground and leaning on it. “Because you’re wearing a Horde uniform. And you just happened to find your way into the Whispering Woods. *And* you just happened to try and steal our sword.”

Catra climbed to her feet with ease. She must’ve been well-trained, despite her lack of a badge Horde captains were known

to wear. Adora stood and moved closer to Glimmer. This girl might be tied up, but she was still a potential threat.

"*Your* sword? Oh, please. I found it before you."

"Doesn't matter. The Whispering Woods is Rebellion territory. You're just lucky you made it this far. Come on, guys. Let's get this spy back to Bright Moon where she can be interrogated properly." Glimmer grabbed Adora and Bow each by an arm and pulled them away from Catra, who watched them with boredom.

"Sure, sure," she said, waving both of her hands. "Go have your little team meeting. I'll just be here waiting for all of the awful things a couple of princesses have in store for me."

Glimmer glared over her shoulder. "Ignoring that," she said. She turned back to Adora and Bow. She looked excited.

"Uh, why are you so happy?" Adora asked.

Glimmer grabbed both of Adora's shoulders and shook her. "Don't you get it, Adora? This is the perfect way to prove to my mom that we're capable of more responsibility."

"Uh…" She looked at Bow, but he was smiling, too. "I don't get it," she said, after a few seconds of watching both of them grin in silence at each other.

"We've just found First Ones tech *and* a Horde spy! When we bring them back to the castle, my mom will be so impressed with us that she'll have to un-ground me! Now, let's get back before she tries to escape."

"What about the sword?" Bow asked. "We still don't know what happened to Adora."

"You and Glimmer should hang onto it for now. We know you guys can hold it without anything happening. We'll figure the rest out when we get back to Bright Moon."

What felt like hours later, Catra was trying to resist scratching her own eyes out as she followed the three Rebellion soldiers through the Whispering Woods.

"Are you sure we're going the right way, Glimmer?" Bow asked.

"I know what I'm doing, Bow," Glimmer snapped, so shrilly it made Catra's hair stand on end. She hissed under her breath. "Can you please just trust me for once?"

In Catra's opinion, Glimmer was spending more time staring at the tracker in her hands than where she was actually walking. Catra had been waiting for the better part of an hour for her to trip over a rock or faceplant into a tree.

Adora—the buff blonde who'd passed out earlier—was the only tolerable one. She must've been in charge of keeping close to Catra, in case she tried to escape. Or, at least, that's what Catra assumed she was doing, judging by how closely she'd been walking to her the entire time. She might've been with the other two, but at least she didn't talk as much.

"You know I always trust you," Bow said, continuing their fruitless argument. "But I'm starting to get a little freaked out. I mean, I pretty much grew up in these woods, and I've never even seen this part of them." His voice pitched lower, reminding Catra of Octavia telling horror stories of what happened to people who tried to cross Hordak to scare the other cadets when they were kids. "I've heard stories about weird stuff out here."

Beside her, Adora stumbled. Catra eyed her with curiosity. She wouldn't meet Catra's gaze, but she straightened and pulled on her dumb light blue jacket. Whatever happened to her earlier must still be affecting her, though she was trying to hide it.

Glimmer huffed. “It’s fine, okay? Just let me figure this out.” She teleported away before Bow could respond.

“Okay, touchy!” he said, walking ahead of Catra and Adora to clear vines and low-hanging branches before they could smack them on the head. “Sorry about her,” he said over his shoulder. “Usually she’s really nice.”

Catra snorted. “Yeah, she seems like a real sweetheart.”

Adora laughed. Catra looked at her, surprised. She didn’t know what it was about this girl, who hung around the crown princess of Bright Moon but claimed not to be one herself despite whatever strange episode she’d had earlier. Catra almost—as stupid as she knew it sounded—felt like she knew her. It was impossible, but… she was so familiar, somehow.

Adora met her eyes and, after a moment of hesitation, she smiled.

Catra’s attention was pulled back to Glimmer, who kept teleporting herself around the immediate area. She was still studying that dumb tracker pad.

“So,” Bow said, slowing his pace to walk beside Catra and Adora. “What made you decide to join the Horde?”

His voice was pleasant, conversational, but Catra wasn’t fooled. He was the crown princess’s best buddy; he might act friendly, but Catra knew better than to trust anyone. She’d tried for years to earn Shadow Weaver’s affection, and it had never done her any good.

“Didn’t have a choice,” was all she said.

Adora turned to her. “I don’t believe that. Everyone has a choice. You have to know that we’re not the bad guys here.”

“‘Bad guys’?” Catra asked, unimpressed. “What are you, five? I was raised by the Horde. It’s my home. So, no. I didn’t have a

choice. And I don't really care about whose side is morally superior. I'm just trying to survive."

Catra could feel Adora's stare burning into her. She ignored it.

"Well," Bow said, "have you thought about leaving? You're out right now; you could just—"

Before he could finish revealing whatever brilliant plan he'd devised, Glimmer starting whining from somewhere close by. Catra let herself be pulled along by Adora.

When they found Glimmer, she was standing among what looked like the ruins of a village.

For the first time that day, Bow looked upset. Adora's face was grim.

Glimmer stooped and picked up a piece of a broken clay painting with two figures, a parent and child, holding hands.

A Horde bot smoldered in the wreckage.

Glimmer turned on her heel, finger in Catra's face.

"I bet you were part of the raiding party that did this."

Catra scoffed. "If I was that important to the Horde, I wouldn't have left in the first place. I'm just another one of Hordak's faceless minions, and Shadow Weaver's punching bag."

A strange look crossed Adora's face. "Shadow Weaver...?" she mumbled.

"Hordak's right hand. She's the reason I never got anywhere in the Horde."

Adora still looked curious, but she didn't press Catra.

"Why would you *want* to make it with them?" Glimmer asked. She still looked furious.

“I told you, Sparkles: the Horde raised me. I didn’t have any other choice. You fall in line, or you’re taken care of.”

“And if you’d been given the choice, you would’ve helped to destroy this village without question,” Glimmer shot back. “Don’t pretend you’re any better than the rest of them. You’re heartless.”

“You’re right,” Catra agreed. She didn’t care what this spoiled princess thought of her. She’d always done what she’d had to survive.

“Whoa, Glimmer,” Bow said gently. He touched her shoulder.

“Don’t say that, Glimmer,” Adora said. “That’s not fair, and you know it.” Catra looked at her, surprised.

There was a fire in her eyes that reminded Catra of the way some of the cadets bonded together, becoming as close as Catra imagined families were. Something she’d never found with any of the others.

“Catra can’t help where she was born anymore than the rest of us. I didn’t choose to be rescued by the Rebellion when I was a baby; it’s no different for Catra. We can’t judge her for that.” Her chest was rising more than before, and her cheeks had a slight redness. “She was probably raised to believe we’re the evil ones, just like we’ve been told about the Horde.”

Glimmer opened her mouth to argue, but Catra cut her off.

“Yeah, they try that. Their brainwashing works on most of us, but I know Hordak and Shadow Weaver are just in it for power.”

“See?” Glimmer said, throwing her arms up in frustration. “She knows they’re wrong.”

“I might not be under any illusions, but that doesn’t change my situation.”

“Glimmer, she’s right. I mean, if Adora had grown up in the Horde, she’d think like them. You know she’s not evil,” Bow said.

Glimmer gritted her teeth, but she didn’t keep arguing. “Fine. I’ll teleport ahead and make sure it’s safe.” Adora and Bow looked like they wanted to argue, but she disappeared before they could.

Adora sighed. “Come on. We need to get Catra and the sword back to Bright Moon and tell the Queen what we know.”

Catra looked back at her.

“How do you know my name?” she demanded.

Before Catra could push further, demand to know how this random Rebellion soldier knew who she was or why she’d been in Catra’s dreams, a scream erupted from the trees, where Glimmer had disappeared.

She emerged from the trees, eyes wide with terror.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked, running to Glimmer’s side.

“There’s something out there—something big.”

“How big?” Bow asked.

Before Glimmer could answer, the ground started shaking. Catra lost her footing and, with her hands bound, she fell hard onto her side. There was nothing within reach she could grab onto. She squeezed her eyes shut.

A hand grabbed her shoulder. She opened her eyes and found Adora’s clear blue ones staring into hers.

Catra watched her warily.

The ground cracked open, and a giant mechanical spider the size of one of the Horde’s bots crawled out, hissing.

“Come on,” Adora said, an urgency to her tone. “You need to get up so I can free your hands!”

“Why would you do that?” Catra asked. She might’ve defended Catra to her friends, but she was still with the Rebellion and Catra was still with the Horde. Good faith only extended so far.

“I won’t let you get hurt just because you’re with the Horde,” Adora said. Her voice was steady with conviction that reflected in her eyes. “You need to be able to defend yourself.”

Something like hope tightened in Catra’s chest. She sat up enough for Adora to reach her hands and was pulled to her feet. Adora pulled a small knife from somewhere on her uniform and sliced through the ropes on Catra’s wrists.

“What are you doing?” Glimmer yelled over the noise. “We can’t trust her! She probably sent this thing after us!”

“When would she have done that? She’s been with us this entire time! We can’t leave her tied up while we fight this thing.”

Catra watched Adora and Glimmer stare each other down in a silent conversation. Glimmer broke first.

“Fine, but she’s not getting her hands on the sword.”

“Glimmer, look out!” Bow shouted.

The spider was standing over Glimmer, one of its legs raised. Just before it could come down on her, Glimmer teleported away. She’d dropped the sword, and it lay next to the hole the spider’s leg left in the ground. Bow was caught up in trying to find a weak spot on the spider with his arrows.

Adora grabbed the sword, and the spider charged at her. She swung with both hands. As soon as the blade made contact with the spider, light erupted from the gem set into the hilt of the sword.

Adora's arms shook from the weight of the spider bearing down on her, and for a moment, Catra thought she was going to pass out again. But when she opened her eyes again, they were glowing as bright as the sword.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" she cried, making the gem glow brighter.

Catra had to cover her eyes against the light. It still shone through her eyelids, and when she adjusted enough to the light, she opened them. In Adora's place stood the strange version of her from Catra's dream.

She seemed to draw strength from the sword, wielding it easier now, as if it weighed as much as the knife she'd used on Catra's binds. She charged the spider.

"Bow!" Adora called. "Did you hit a weak spot?"

"Y-yeah, on it's left side, between the first and second legs! There's some wiring poking out."

"I see it!"

Catra watched as the girl who had essentially thrown her from a cliff in her dream single-handedly took down a giant mechanical Horde spider twice her size.

Catra noticed smoke streaming from the spot Bow'd described. Adora singled in on it, swinging her sword upward. The spider moved just in time to avoid the blow, and the sword glanced harmlessly off the spider.

"I can't get to it!" She struck again, more forceful this time, but the spider didn't seem to notice.

"I've got this," Catra said, running past Adora. She got directly in the spider's line of sight. It hissed and made for her.

“What’re you—” Adora started, but Catra kept her attention on the spider. She circled from a distance, and it turned with her.

Adora must’ve recognized the opening Catra was trying to give her, because she disappeared from sight and, a minute later, the spider collapsed to the ground.

Catra coughed and covered her eyes from the dust. When it settled and she could see again, she noticed that the spider's once-blue eyes were black. Thick smoke billowed from where Adora must’ve hit it, making Catra’s eyes water.

Adora jogged up to her, grinning, eyes bright with excitement. Her face was flushed, but she was hardly sweating. She looked like she could go up against an army of bots and still have energy to spare.

“What just happened?” Bow asked, voice cracking.

Adora looked away from her first.

“Adora,” Glimmer said, drawing her name out like it was unfamiliar in her mouth. “Can we talk to you for a minute? In private,” she said, glancing at Catra.

“Uh, we’ll be right back,” Adora told her. Catra watched the three of them walk off together. It was a testament to Glimmer’s shock that she didn’t look back at Catra to make sure she didn’t run away.

Catra perched on a rock to wait. How had she seen Adora—known her name, known, somehow, that she was a princess with special powers—before they’d ever met? How had she dreamt of the sword before she’d known it existed?

More important, what was Catra going to do? Adora was obviously linked to the sword. Should Catra risk trying to take it from her? She’d seen in her dream how strong Adora was, *felt* her power. It was even more impressive in real life. There was no way she’d be able to fight her for it.

Did she even want the sword anymore? If she did somehow get it, what was she going to do then? She didn't particularly want to go back to the Fright Zone, but she knew she'd only be able to return if she had the sword. Or if, miraculously, she could convince Adora to go with her. Shadow Weaver had been oddly obsessed with her in Catra's dream. Did she know about her?

Whatever Adora's powers were, she'd be unstoppable with the sword. Hordak would *have* to promote Catra if she brought her to their side.

Or maybe…

Maybe she could go back to Bright Moon with Adora. Just to find useful information, of course. Then she could escape and return to the Horde. Tell them she'd been kidnapped. She could figure out a way to explain why she'd taken a skiff.

Maybe, though… She could stay at Bright Moon. Make a new home. Get to know Adora and how they were connected. They had to be. There was no way she'd randomly had a dream about her if they weren't.

Catra was pulled from her thoughts by the others returning.

"… just get back to Bright Moon," Glimmer was saying. She turned to Catra, eyes narrowed. "Why are you still here?"

Catra resisted the urge to roll her eyes. "Enjoying the scenery," she said instead, fake-cheer in her tone. "Why, you want me to leave?"

"No, really," Bow insisted. "Why haven't you escaped by now?"

Catra looked between the three of them. Glimmer looked as distrustful as ever, but Bow looked strangely hopeful. Adora's face mirrored how Catra felt; her gaze was searching.

Like Catra was someone she couldn't quite place in her memory.

Adora lost track of how long it'd been since they'd left the castle the night before. The sun was hidden by the tall trees, so she couldn't tell if it was past midday or not.

At some point, she began to hear music playing from somewhere in the trees. As they walked, the music got stronger, until eventually, they came across a small village where a live band was playing.

There were dozens of people, all wearing colorful tunics. A lot of them had flowers either in their hair or pinned to their clothes.

"This must be Thaymor," Bow said. "I knew it wasn't far from Bright Moon, but I've never actually been here before."

"Well, we just need to ask someone how to get back to the castle. In and out, people," Glimmer said.

Adora moved to walk out of the clearing, but Glimmer stopped her. "Wait! She needs a disguise." She was eyeing Catra's clothes with disgust.

"Why?" Catra asked, arms folded over her chest.

"You look like a Horde soldier!"

Catra rolled her eyes, apparently unconcerned. "Then they'll leave me alone."

"Or they'll run in terror."

"Glimmer, she looks fine," Bow said, trying to quell the brewing argument. "She's not the only one here wearing red."

"Fine, but you're in charge of babysitting her to make sure she doesn't get in trouble." She stalked ahead, irritation clear in the

set of her shoulders.

“So what is this?” Catra asked, looking around.

“It’s a festival,” Bow said.

Catra gave him a blank stare.

“Y’know, like a big party?”

Her expression didn’t change.

Bow stopped walking. Glimmer didn’t notice and kept walking, but Adora waited with Bow.

“You don’t have parties in the Fright Zone?” he asked Catra, horrified.

She raised an eyebrow.

Bow gasped.

Glimmer stomped back over to them. “Did you even hear what I just said? In and out, Bow!”

Bow grabbed Glimmer by the shoulders. “Glimmer, she has never been to a party before! This is serious!”

Glimmer looked to Adora for help. Adora shrugged.

Bow grabbed glimmer by the hand and led her to a stall where a Thaymorian was selling food. He waved over his shoulder for Adora and Catra to follow.

He ordered something Adora didn’t recognize and handed it to Catra, who reluctantly accepted it. She sniffed it before taking a bite. When she did, her eyes lit up.

“Good?” Adora asked, stifling a laugh.

Catra gave her a side-eye look but took another bite, bigger this time.

A man came up behind Glimmer, who was still glaring at Bow, and placed a flower crown on her head when she wasn't paying attention. She swatted at him.

Despite Glimmer's insistence, they stayed at the festival for hours. Catra seemed much more willing to try the different foods, and Adora met a horse she instantly fell in love with.

"So, seriously," Bow said, when the party had started to wind down. "No parties ever? What do you do on your birthday?"

Adora was leaning against a tree, eating some cotton candy. Catra was perched on a tree branch above her head, watching everything with wide eyes.

"Huh?" Catra said, distracted.

Bow gaped at her, then at Adora, as if he couldn't believe it. "No birthdays either? How is your life this sad?"

"What, did you think we actually get to have fun in the Horde?" Catra's voice was sharper than it'd been since they'd met her that morning.

Before she could stop herself, Adora asked, "How could you stay with them, knowing what they do to people?"

Catra sighed, but she didn't look angry. "I thought we went over this already."

"You said earlier that you didn't have a choice in joining the Horde. Well, you do now."

"What?" Catra narrowed her eyes.

"You could come to Bright Moon with us."

“Uh, I thought that’s what we were doing. I didn’t handcuff myself, remember? Or did becoming a princess scramble your brain?”

“Not as our prisoner. As our ally. You could live there.”

Catra scoffed. “You kidnapped me, and you think I’m going to join your side? You really are brain damaged.”

“You said you didn’t have a choice about joining the Horde, and you’re right. But I’m giving you one now. You can leave the Horde and fight with me in the Rebellion—save Etheria. Or you can rejoin the Horde. Then you’ll be no better than the rest of them.”

“Who said I wanted to be better? I’m just trying to survive.”

“And what happens when you go back? When we found you, you were wandering alone in the Whispering Woods at night. We didn’t capture you in the Fright Zone; you were in our territory. Do you plan on telling your boss why you were wandering around Alliance territory in the middle of the night by yourself?”

“How do you know I wasn’t on a mission?”

“I’ve been a soldier for the Rebellion as long as you’ve been one for the Horde; I know how it operates. The Horde always attacks with an army.”

“You don’t know anything about us.”

“I’m a captain in Queen Angella’s army; it’s my job to know about you. The Horde wouldn’t be stupid enough to send a lone soldier into the Whispering Woods in the middle of the night without backup. So what were you really doing out there, Catra?”

“None of your business, Princess,” Catra snapped. She wouldn’t meet Adora’s eyes.

Somehow, Adora could tell she wasn’t really angry. “Whatever you say, Runaway.”

The party was interrupted, suddenly and violently, by what sounded like a cannon blast. Adora looked to where it came from. Smoke streamed from the tops of the trees.

Screams erupted in the air.

The horse Adora had been petting jumped on its hind legs, spooked.

“What’s going on?” Bow asked.

Adora took off running to find the source of the smoke.

One minute, she was running, and the next, she was standing in the middle of Thaymor as it burned. She couldn’t remember getting there.

“What…?” All of a sudden, her temple throbbed, a sharp spike of pain she’d never experienced before. Her vision flickered, and she saw double.

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Glimmer asked, alarmed.

“Head hurts,” she said through gritted teeth. “I can’t see.”

Beside her, Catra also cried out in pain. “Ah!”

“What’s wrong with them?” Glimmer’s voice was muffled, like she was speaking from above water.

“I don’t know!” Bow said.

Then, as suddenly as she’d gotten across the village, Adora was standing at the edge of the Whispering Woods. Her head didn’t hurt as bad, but she felt a dull pressure building in her forehead.

“What’s happening?” Catra asked. “When did we get here?”

Adora was glad she wasn’t the only one who felt like she was losing gaps of time. “I don’t know.”

“What are you talking about?” Bow asked.

Adora gasped.

Behind Bow stood a woman in a long red gown, her face hidden beneath a steel red mask. Tendrils of what looked like smoke curled around her feet, obscuring the ground beneath her and making it look like she was floating.

“There’s a Horde soldier!”

“Adora, what are you talking about?” Bow’s voice was gentle, but it didn’t calm her like it usually did. “There’s nothing there.”

“But—” Adora whirled around, ready to show Bow that, yes, she was *right there,* but he was right. The woman was gone.

The forest shook around them.

“Wha—what’s happening?” Adora stumbled and grabbed a tree trunk for balance. Her vision flickered again, and suddenly, she wasn’t in the middle of the party anymore. All of it—the houses, the decorations, Glimmer, Bow—gone.

She was alone with Catra, back in the clearing where they’d found the sword.

Adora’s temple throbbed. It hurt so much she had to close her eyes to block out the light. She cried out and fell to her knees.

Her mind exploded, suddenly too full with visions, or dreams, or—

Memories.

So many that she had a hard time picking anything out. All but one.

She saw herself in a red dress, pressed up against a suit-clad Catra, who led around a crowded ballroom.

Princess Prom.

The Alliance.

Adora hadn't grown up with Glimmer and Bow. She—she'd grown up in the *Horde.* With Catra. She used to be *part* of the Horde.

Yes, a voice said in her mind. *Adora. Find the portal.*

Light Hope.

She'd seen Light Hope, she'd talked to her. Light Hope had tried to tell her when she first touched the sword earlier that something was wrong. Adora had thought it was a dream.

Still shaky, she forced herself to her feet. Catra's face was bloodless, like she'd seen a ghost.

She'd seen Shadow Weaver, too. She'd remembered.

So did Adora. She remembered being taken from the Crimson Waste, stripped of the sword, being tied up in Hordak's lair. Begging Entrapta not to open a portal.

The others coming to rescue her. Being too late.

Catra looking into her eyes as she activated the portal.

Waking up in Bright Moon with memories of a life she'd never lived.

Growing up with Glimmer and Bow… It'd all been a cruel trick. Adora should've known. Her life had never been that simple.

"It was you," Adora breathed. Her head was still throbbing, but she ignored it. "You took me, and—and the sword. You opened a *portal,* even though you knew it would destroy everything! I *told* you—" Adora cut herself off, trying to tamp down her growing panic.

She had to fix this. She had to find a way to get back to the others, seal the portal— *something.* She had to do *something* .

Catra stared back at Adora, fear in her expression, but she shook her head. "You—you're *wrong.* I never met you until this morning, I didn't know about the sword. I've never even been in Hordak's lair!"

"You know I'm right. I've seen the way you watch me; you felt like something was off, too. You recognized me when you saw me, didn't you?"

Catra's throat bobbed as she swallowed. "No. You can't be right, you can't."

"Why? Why are you trying to hold onto this? It's over, Catra. Your plan failed."

Catra pulled at her hair, making it stick up more than usual. "No! *No.* Because if you're right, if none of this is *real,* then you did leave me. You *left* me. You chose them over me! And Shadow Weaver chose you over me *again* . She came for you again, and she never cared about me."

Adora's throat burned. "Catra, Shadow Weaver doesn't care about me."

"Yes—"

"No, Catra, listen to me! Shadow Weaver doesn't care about anyone. She only cares about my power and how she can use it. It has nothing to do with you not being good enough."

Catra covered her ears with her hands. "Stop. Just—stop!"

Adora took a step closer to her. "You know I wanted you to come with me when I left the Fright Zone. I never wanted to leave you behind. You chose to stay."

"No, you chose them! I wasn't enough for you. I couldn't make you stay even though you've known me your whole life. I've always been there for you, and you chose them anyway."

"You know that's not fair," Adora protested.

Catra laughed. It was a sharp, bitter thing. "Fair? You wanna talk to me about *fair?* I've spent my whole life living in your shadow. You were always the golden child, always Shadow Weaver's favorite. Becoming Force Captain wasn't enough for you. You had to go and become a *princess,* too."

"I didn't choose the sword, Catra!"

"No, you're right. It chose you. Just like everything else."

Adora didn't know how to respond. Catra was right about this. She didn't know why—and she'd accepted by now that she probably never would—but the sword did choose her. Over Glimmer, over Catra, over anyone else it could've had. Adora never asked for it, though, and if she'd had her way in the beginning, she would've gone back to the Horde, to the family she'd known since she was born.

With Catra by her side.

Leaving her behind to go to Bright Moon with Glimmer and Bow had been one of the hardest decisions she'd ever had to make. And she'd had to do it over and over again, every time she faced Catra as an enemy.

"You couldn't just let it be, could you?" Catra snapped. She was holding back tears.

Adora wouldn't have been able to tell before getting her memories back, but she'd grown up with Catra. She knew her better than she knew herself. Despite everything.

Adora took another step toward her. "Catra, what are you talking about?"

Catra waved her arms, gesturing to the forest around them. "This! Everything! We could've started over." She dropped her voice to nearly a whisper. "We could've been happy." Her voice cracked.

Adora wanted to wrap her arms around Catra, keep her from hurting. She couldn't, though. None of this was right. "How? Catra, none of this is *real.* We can't just live in a fantasy world and pretend that nothing ever happened."

"Yes, we can! I'm not the bad guy here. You can bring me back with you to Bright Moon and we can take down the Horde together."

Tears pooled in Adora's eyes. She squeezed them shut. "It's not *real,"* she whispered. "I don't want to forget you, no matter how much we've hurt each other. I don't want to pretend."

Catra didn't say anything. Adora opened her eyes; Catra was staring at her like she didn't believe what she was saying.

"You'd really want to forget everything we've been through together? Everything we've been to each other?" Adora couldn't mask the hurt in her voice. Somehow, this was worse than knowing that Catra hated her when she first left the Horde. She could handle that, because she had just as many reasons to hate Catra.

But Adora had never, not once in the time since she'd left the Horde, wanted to erase Catra from her memories. Not her best parts, not the worst things she'd done.

Despite all of it, Adora would always love Catra. She'd always be Adora's first friend, first crush, first love. She wouldn't choose to exchange it for a world where they were strangers, even if it meant a clean slate where things were less complicated.

Nothing had ever been easy for them, when they were kids. Adora had known, even then, that Catra had resented how much Shadow Weaver praised her. She'd always felt guilty for it, known it was the reason Catra had started to slack off in drills. Why, when they'd gotten older, she'd stopped showing up altogether.

Adora didn't care about easy; she never had. She always worked hard for what she wanted, whether that was a position as Force

Captain or a Rebel commander. Her relationship with Catra.

That something they'd been, in-between friends and lovers, just on the cusp of something more.

How, for the last day, it felt they were again. Before she remembered.

"Adora," Catra said, reaching for her hand for the first time in so long. "Please."

Adora leaned closer. "Please what?" she asked, nearly a whisper.

"I want you to stay."

"I can't." Catra pulled her hand away, and Adora immediately chased it. "You can't either. This isn't real."

"Stop saying that!"

"Catra, *look."*

Around them, the ground was starting to crack apart, revealing slivers of violet light. The same color as the portal.

"This forest is literally disappearing! And we will too if we don't get out of here." Adora reached for Catra's hand again. This time, she didn't pull away. "Catra, *please.* You can come back to Bright Moon with me once we get out of here. We can start over there, in the real world."

"How?" Catra's voice was thin. "I don't know how to come back from this."

Adora flinched. "Back from the portal, or back from us?"

"Both."

Adora waited until Catra met her eyes. "We'll figure it out, I promise. We can fix it together."

Catra's smile was sad. "You've said that to me before. When we were kids. You promised me everything would be okay if we stayed together. And then you left."

Adora closed her eyes. "I'm not leaving without you this time."

Catra squeezed her hand. "Okay."

Adora felt like she'd forgotten to breathe. "Really?" Hope betrayed any caution she should've had.

Catra exhaled. "Yeah. How do we get out of here?"

The ground beneath them cracked, spreading until it caved in under their feet.

They were separated by the chasm that was steadily getting wider between them. The light was so bright that Adora could barely see Catra.

"Adora!" Catra cried. The ground was crumbling under her feet.

"You'll have to jump across!"

"I can't, it's too wide!"

"Yes, you can!"

Catra's face was full of fear, doubt, but Adora hoped she would listen.

Catra jumped.

Adora thought she would make it.

She fell short, but managed to get a hold of a piece of rock jutting from the top of the ledge at Adora's feet. "Adora!"

"Hang on!" Adora got onto her stomach and reached for Catra's hand, but she lost her grip as the ground shook beneath her and toppled forward into the hole.

She felt Catra grab for her, but she fell too fast for Catra to catch her.

She fell.

Suddenly, Adora was on her feet. She opened her eyes. She was in the middle of Hordak's lair, and Catra was beside her.

Hordak was nowhere to be found, but Shadow Weaver stood with Bow, Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta.

"How did you guys get here?" Adora asked. "Where's Glim—"

"Adora, here!" Adora turned and saw Glimmer, the sword in hand.

Adora took it, then pulled Glimmer into a hug.

Glimmer stiffened in surprise at first, but she hugged back.

"I missed you," Adora said into her hair. She'd been with Glimmer all day, but it wasn't really her. Not the Glimmer whom Adora had fought side by side with, whom she'd watched mature into her own person but worked to make her mother proud.

"You, too," Glimmer said, voice muffled by Adora's shoulder. "I'm glad you're okay."

"Touching as this all is," Shadow Weaver's deep voice cut in, "we need to go. *Now."*

Glimmer broke their hug first and strode to Shadow Weaver, whose hand was outstretched. Adora watched, confused, as the others gathered around them.

"Adora, let's go. Shadow Weaver's gonna help Glimmer teleport us out of here," Bow explained.

Adora looked at Catra, who seemed like she was about to make a run for the door. "If you don't want to go with her, we'll find

another way out."

Catra seemed surprised by the offer, but she shook her head. "No, it's fine. If Sparkles thinks she can get us all out of here, I'd rather leave before the ceiling caves in on my head."

Adora took her hand, and they joined the others.

They landed under the Moonstone.

In her periphery, Adora saw Catra immediately back away from Shadow Weaver.

"We did it!" Glimmer cheered. The others joined in, and Adora watched with a mix of amusement and trepidation as Perfuma pulled Shadow Weaver into a hug.

"Glimmer!" Everyone turned to Angella, who dropped down onto the platform. She ran to Glimmer. "I was so worried," she said, wrapping her in a hug.

"Oh boy," Adora muttered. She grabbed Catra's hand and guided her away from what was probably going to turn into a fight.

"Where are we going?" Catra asked warily.

"Well, we both need rest, first of all. And… we should probably talk."

"Do we have to?" Catra whined. She let Adora pull her along, though.

Adora brought Catra to her room, since she didn't feel like waiting for a room to be prepared for Catra. And judging by how fidgety Catra was being since they'd entered the castle, Adora assumed she didn't want to be alone right now.

"It's so… bright in here."

Adora snorted. “It’s called *Bright* Moon.”

“Ugh, it’s awful. How can you get any sleep at night?”

Adora smiled.

She considered taking a shower, but the thought of staying on her feet right now exhausted her. Instead, she sat on her bed and kicked off her boots.

Catra hovered by the door, like she was afraid to come any closer.

“You can sit, you know,” Adora teased, trying to ease the tension.

Catra didn’t move.

Adore decided not to push it. Instead, she asked, “What happened after I fell? Did you fall into the portal, too?”

“I let go,” Catra said. As if it were the most casual thing in the world.

“What?” Adora was sure she misheard.

Catra finally moved further into the room, until she was barely a foot away from Adora. “I let go.”

“Why would you do that?”

Catra smirked. “You’re not the only one who gets to make ridiculous self-sacrifices.”

Adora stared at her, stunned.

Catra began to fidget under her gaze. “You promised we would fix it together. I couldn’t let you break your promise twice,” she admitted.

“Oh,” Adora said.

“Yeah.” Catra was picking at her fingernails; Adora loved seeing it as much as it made her sick. It was a habit she’d developed when they were kids, an attempt at resisting the urge to scratch her own skin when she felt anxious or upset.

The room fell silent between them.

Adora pushed herself to her feet, even though her body ached with exhaustion. She felt like she’d just shoved an entire week into the last eighteen hours. But she knew that if she didn’t say this now, she never would.

Catra watched her wearily, but Adora saw the smallest glint of hope in her face.

She topped in front of Catra. Took a deep breath.

“Look, I know we have a lot of problems we need to work through before we can begin to go back to the way things used to be. Or, at least, as close as we can get. But, the thing is, I don’t want things to go back to the way they were.”

Adora watched Catra close herself off, a mask of indifference she’d rarely ever seen directed at her.

“No, wait. Don’t shut me out yet; I’m not done.”

Catra crossed her arms.

Adora huffed. “You never let me have it easy. Okay, so, what I mean is… Look. Before all of this—before She-ra, before I was even promoted to Force Captain—it was just you and me. Best friends who wanted to run the Horde together when we got older. And I loved that—so much.” Adora felt her cheeks get hot, and she scratched the back of her neck. “But, at some point, I also realized that I…”

“Just spit it out, Ponytail,” Catra said. Adora hadn’t heard that teasing edge to her voice in so long. She hadn’t realized how much she missed it.

She smiled and forced herself to relax. This was *Catra,* the girl she;d known since before they could talk. “Fine, jeez, I’ll say it.” Catra grinned.

“At some point, I fell for you. It took me a long time to realize—like, an embarrassingly long time—” Catra raised an eyebrow; Adora ignored her. “I think I’ve loved you pretty much forever, actually,” she admitted.

“Love, huh?” Catra asked. “Pretty intense stuff, coming from someone who was raised by Shadow Weaver.”

Adora laughed, surprised. She hadn’t thought she’d ever be able to joke about the woman who’d put her and the friends she’d grown up with through so much trauma, but Catra’s way of coping had always been to make light of things she didn’t want to face. Another thing they’d have to work on.

“Yeah, well, getting out of the Fright Zone made me realize that life can actually be happy.”

Catra looked away.

“Hey,” Adora said, softer. “You know you can stay, right? Not just to help in the war. You can make a life here—you can be happy.”

“Why?” she asked. “Why would you want me here, after everything I’ve done to you? How could you still have feelings for me?”

“Hey, stop. We went through this already. We’ve both hurt each other, not just you. But I think we deserve to be more than our mistakes. We’ve been through just as much together. I won’t throw that away over a war we were forced to choose sides in.”

Catra still wouldn’t meet her eyes.

“You told me in that other world that you didn’t have a choice, and I told you that you did. That choice still exists, even though that life doesn’t. You just have to make it.”

When she spoke, Catra's voice was rough. "So you still want me?" It was more vulnerable than Adora had ever heard her.

"More than ever. I know you're ready to get out of there."

Catra laughed. "God, yeah. More than anything." She sniffled and wiped a hand over her face. "Ugh. Coming here has already turned me into a sap."

Adora grabbed her hand. "Having emotions doesn't make you weak. It shows that you're strong enough to live in a world that will try to break you."

"I don't like it," Catra said. Adora laughed. "But… I think I'll have to get used to it."

Adora felt her heart quicken. "Yeah?"

"Yeah. I want to stay here. With you."

Adora felt the rest of the tension she'd been carrying since the portal opened leave her. She leaned in close enough that she could feel Catra's soft breath on her cheeks. "So, now what?"

Catra laughed. She'd lost all of her earlier uncertainty, replaced by a boldness Adora hadn't seen in years. "I think this is when you kiss me."

"Do you want me to?" she asked. Her nerves were finally catching up with her. She felt like she was fifteen again, when she had first started to notice Catra—the way she made Adora feel different than anyone else. Back when Adora wouldn't dare to let herself think about doing anything about it, instead throwing herself into training.

"Adora," Catra said, her voice low with a different emotion. "Stop thinking."

Then she kissed her.

End Notes

i really hope you enjoyed because this took AGES

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!